Three days later, after intense negotiations, a triumphant Hazare emerged from Tihar jail, was lifted onto a truck and taken to the Ramlila Maidan where he had decided to continue with his fast. The motorcade from Tihar to Ramlila Maidan via Rajghat was another made-for-television moment. Thousands of delirious Hazare supporters cheered him along, showering him with petals and garlands. For the next week, Hazare would sit impassively on a special stage erected at the maidan, a life-size portrait of Mahatma Gandhi in the background. The eyes of an entire nation were riveted on one elderly man, now being projected as a modern-day Gandhi.

Meanwhile, an anxious government was forced to hold a special debate in the Lok Sabha on Hazare's proposed Lok Pal Bill. The House, after much sound and fury, virtually agreed to all of Hazare's conditions. On 28 August, Hazare broke his fast with a clenched fist and a 'Bharat Mata ki Jai' war cry. A social activist in the autumn of his life had been transformed into an iconic figure taking on the government of the world's largest democracy.

That wasn't the last act of Lok Pal-related errors committed by the UPA-II government in 2011. As the clock wound down to usher in another year, the government made another attempt to pass the contentious bill in Parliament. After being passed in the Lok Sabha, it was brought to the Rajya Sabha. There, amidst chaotic scenes, the bill was torn up by Rajniti Prasad, an MP from Lalu Prasad Yadav's RJD, even as the treasury benches looked on helplessly. Close to midnight, amidst the cacophony, Vice President Hamid Ansari, who was chairman of the Rajya Sabha, adjourned the House. The Opposition accused the government of stage-managing the show. The verdict of the analysts in the studio was unanimous—the UPA had committed political hara-kiri.

Why did the UPA get it all so horribly wrong? Why did canny experienced politicians like Mukherjee, Chidambaram, Khurshid, Sibal fail to deal with what was, after all, a fledgling movement being run by a curious mix of activists of varying backgrounds? Anna Hazare wasn't Mahatma Gandhi; he wasn't even Jayaprakash Narayan. His politics had been honed in a village panchayat where he had originally been an